

SEALED SOLUTION

Stop here until you commit.

This file reveals the investigation, the identities, and the ending. Keep it separate from the player packet.

Before continuing, write your conclusion, cite the records that support it, and name an uncertainty the file does not resolve.

Read the evidence-cited solution first. The expanded aftermath follows the original ending. It develops the human consequences; it does not supply a clue needed to solve the case.

A blank reverse follows this cover so the first answer starts on a fresh sheet when this file is printed on both sides.

The answer is overleaf.

Keep this file closed until your written reconstruction is complete.

The name before Sutton

Read this before the private letter.

01 / THE STARTING CONTRADICTION

BB01 calls Mabel the Suttons' daughter, while Edith reports no children born and none living. The census alone could contain an error; it also does not settle Thomas's biological relationship. BB02 supplies the foundling account and BB20 explicitly places that found infant with Thomas and Edith. Together they make the Sutton household a caregiving identity to investigate, rather than a sufficient birth identity.

02 / THE BIRTH IDENTITY

Mabel Reilly, born 11 February 1900, daughter of Patrick Reilly and Nora Flynn Reilly. BB18 records that birth directly. BB07 puts infant Mabel in their household in June 1900. BB02's estimated age, BB09's maternal death, the later household pattern, and the alternate candidates' continued identities support the match. The birth entry establishes who Mabel Reilly was; it is the combined case that identifies her with Mabel Sutton.

03 / THE TURNING POINT

Nora died on 22 September 1900. The infant was found on 30 September 1900: eight days later. Use BB09 and BB02. October 1 is the newspaper publication date and the day the Suttons take the infant home in BB20, not the day the basket was found.

For full credit: explain the opening contradiction without treating one census field as infallible; give the original name, birthday, and both parents; calculate the interval from the event dates.

The family behind the name

A pattern across records, with limits kept visible.

04 / THE HOUSEHOLD PATTERN

BB07 shows **ten children** with Patrick and Nora, twelve household members in all. At least three of these later matches satisfy the deduction:

Child	Later household	Recorded role	Source
John Reilly	Walsh	Boarder; hired hand	BB14
Margaret Reilly	Doyle	Niece	BB11
Thomas Reilly	Bennett	Boarder	BB10
Rose Reilly	O'Brien	Niece	BB12

The pattern supports a family dispersed into several households. A ten-year gap and adult children leaving home do not, by themselves, prove exact placement dates or motives. The pattern gains weight when combined with Nora's death, the infant's disappearance from the supplied Reilly trail, and the foundling account.

05 / THE ALTERNATIVES

Elsie Miller: BB15 records her with Rebecca Hale in 1910. **Nora Keane:** BB16 records her with William and Anna. **Ruth Foster:** BB17 records her departure with Samuel in May 1901. These positive records support continued identities separate from Mabel Sutton within this closed case. Ruth's mother also died before the finding; that coincidence is insufficient. Sarah Miller's death was after the basket appeared.

06 / THE EXPLANATION AND ITS LIMIT

A mother's death left a large household in crisis; the scattered children make a care-related separation the best-supported explanation. **The public papers do not identify who carried the basket.** Naming Patrick at this stage is a hypothesis, not an established observation. The private letter confirms that act.

Ten children. One household.

Patrick Reilly and Nora Flynn Reilly

Patrick and Nora married on 3 June 1878. Their ten children appear together in the June 1900 household. These are the original names and canonical birth dates:

Child	Date of birth	What the play packet establishes
Daniel Reilly	14 January 1879	Later whereabouts not established in the play packet.
Kathleen Reilly	9 June 1881	Later whereabouts not established in the play packet.
Michael Reilly	25 March 1883	Named with Patrick in 1910 / BB13.
Ellen Reilly	16 November 1885	Named with Patrick in 1910 / BB13.
John Reilly	4 July 1887	Walsh household / BB14.
Margaret Reilly	30 September 1889	Doyle household / BB11.
Thomas Reilly	8 December 1891	Bennett household / BB10.
Rose Reilly	17 May 1894	O'Brien household / BB12.
Joseph Reilly	21 August 1897	Later whereabouts not established in the play packet.
Mabel Reilly	11 February 1900	Raised as Mabel Ruth Sutton / case conclusion.

The exact birthdays of the older children are supplied here as family reconstruction, not as clues the player was expected to recover. An untraced person was never meant to be counted as dead.

Mary Flynn Doyle is Nora's younger sister, so Margaret is genuinely Mary's niece. Rose's recorded niece label in the O'Brien household is imprecise: Agnes is not her aunt. Ellen's age of 15 in BB07 also differs from her birth date. Neither discrepancy overturns the wider identity case.

A letter never sent

3 March 1942 / Ohio / retained among family papers

Dear Mabel,

I have written your name at the top of this page and then sat here, wondering which name belongs after it. Sutton is the name you grew up with. Reilly was the name you were born with. You were our baby sister.

Father was Patrick Reilly. Mother was Nora Flynn before she married him. You were born on February 11, 1900, the youngest of ten. My name is Margaret. I was eleven when we lost you from the house.

Mother died on September 22. After that Father could not keep the farm going and care for all of us together. I went to Aunt Mary Doyle. John went to the Walshes, Thomas to the Bennetts, and Rose to the O'Briens. A family can still have all its names and no longer have one home.

Father was the one who left you at Grace Church on September 30. He put you in the basket in a rear pew before the Sunday service. No one there knew whose child you were. Thomas and Edith Sutton took you home the next day.

I do not know how to make an explanation answer for all the years. I can only write the thing that was left out of the story you were given. You had a mother. You had a father. You had nine brothers and sisters. We did not stop being your family because you did not know our names.

I have kept this letter instead of sending it. Perhaps that is another failure to add to the first. But I want the words somewhere outside my own head: you were Mabel Reilly, and you were my sister.

Margaret

D009 / sealed confirmation. This letter is a fictional rendering of the supplied canonical account.

What the letter settles

The finding was a beginning, not the whole family story.

Mabel Ruth Sutton was Mabel Reilly. Margaret's letter confirms the identity and names Patrick as the person who left her at the church. It supplies the private family explanation that the public records could only support indirectly.

The child in the basket was the youngest of ten. Nora's death broke the household apart. The Suttons gave Mabel a home and the name she carried into adulthood; the investigation restores the names of the family she had not known.

WHAT COUNTED AS SOLVING THE CASE

You identified the birth family, supported the match with several records, reconstructed the household pattern, and tested the alternatives. You also recognized where the evidence stopped. The letter rewards that work; it does not replace it.

ABOUT THE RECORDS

The story, 44 canonical people, parentage, major dates, and family placements come from the supplied Baby in a Basket master handoff. The newspaper wording, letter prose, care-book rendering, and page designs were created for this edition. None of the exhibits is an authentic historical record. Unknown spouses, death causes, and untraced later residences were not invented.

Mabel's 1900 census entry retains the handoff's recorded 4/12. Her canonical birthday makes her three completed months old on June 1; the recorded figure is approximate, not a different birthday. The Sutton home placement follows the locked story and event record: October 1, 1900.

HISTORICAL FORM REFERENCES

The selected census fields and reading conventions were checked against U.S. Census Bureau instructions. No historical lookup is required to play.

[U.S. Census Bureau / 1900 Instructions to Enumerators](#)

[U.S. Census Bureau / 1910 Instructions to Enumerators](#)

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AFTER THE CASE

The letter stayed in the drawer

After the sealed letter and answer key

Margaret wrote her sister's name and held the pen above the next line. In 1942, there were words for the family relationship that had been missing from Mabel's own account. There was no sentence that could give the years back.

She wrote Patrick. Nora. The birthday. The ten children. The names were plain enough when set down separately. What had been difficult was making them live in the same letter as what Father had done.

At eleven, she had not been the adult responsible for keeping the household together. Remembering that did not stop her from revisiting the house as if there were an overlooked task she might still complete. Carry something. Fetch someone. Speak before the basket was gone. The mind could keep giving a child duties the child had never possessed the power to carry out.

She did not write a scene she had not witnessed. She wrote the account preserved in the letter: Father had left Mabel at Grace Church. The public records could support the family crisis; this private paper finally named the person who carried out that act.

To explain it was to risk sounding as if she excused it. To give no explanation was to make the family seem incapable of love. She wanted a third way and could not find a sentence that guaranteed how her sister would hear it.

She left the admission about keeping the letter. Perhaps that was another failure. It was the least comfortable line and the one she did not cross out.

When the page was finished, she laid the pen down. The letter remained unsent. What Mabel would have made of it was a question the page could not answer.

What you have recovered is therefore uneven. The identity is strong within the closed case: Mabel Reilly, daughter of Patrick and Nora, later Mabel Ruth Sutton. The private letter confirms Patrick's act. Some siblings can be traced in the supplied households; others remain untraced. The record of a mother raising no biological children does not diminish the home Edith made. The record of a father in crisis does not make the child's loss disappear.

Margaret could put a name on what happened. She could not control what that name would mean to Mabel. The final unfinished business was no longer a missing field in a register. It was the distance between telling a truth somewhere on paper and telling it to the person who had spent a life without it.